

Chapter 5 — Tribes, Nomads and Settled Communities

The one-line point: Chapters 2–4 were about kings. **This one is about everyone the kings couldn't reach** — and about what happened when tribal societies built states of their own. It ends with two superb case studies: the **Gonds** and the **Ahoms**.

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Syllabus Classification

Field	Value
Subject	History → Medieval India
Sub-discipline	Social history — tribes, nomadism, state formation on the frontier
Period	~13th – 18th centuries
Prelims (GS Paper I)	<i>History of India</i> → tribes and their regions, Gond and Ahom administration
Mains (GS Paper I)	★ ★ ★ INDIAN SOCIETY — tribal communities, their marginalisation, and assimilation into caste society
Also feeds	Indian Society (GS1) ★ ★ ★, Polity ★ ★ (Fifth/Sixth Schedules, PESA, Forest Rights Act — this is their historical root), Economy (nomadic trade networks), Geography (Gondwana, Brahmaputra valley)
Weightage	★ ★ ★ — 1–2 Prelims Qs, but disproportionately useful for Mains GS1
Overlaps with	Class 6 Ch.2 (tribal societies, jhum), Ch.1 of this book (jati)

 **Medieval India** → **Social History**. Its real Mains home is **GS1 Indian Society**, where tribal questions recur. Treat this as your historical foundation for every tribal-policy answer.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this chapter you should be able to:

- ☐ **Define** a tribe as NCERT does, and list four ways tribal society differed from caste society.
- ☐ **Explain** why tribal history is hard to write, and what historians now use instead. ★
- ☐ **Map** the major tribes to their regions — Khokhar, Gakkhar, Langah, Balochi, Gaddi, Naga, Ahom, Chero, Munda, Santal, Koli, Berad, Bhil, Gond.
- ☐ **Describe** the **Banjaras** — *tanda*, their role under Alauddin Khalji and the Mughals, and **Peter Mundy's** account. ★
- ☐ **Explain** how *jati** **replaced** **varna* as the organising principle of society. ★ ★
- ☐ **Explain** how tribes entered caste society — and **who benefited and who didn't**. ★ ★
- ☐ **Describe** the **Gond** state: *garh*, *chaurasi*, *barhot*, and the Garha Katanga story.
- ☐ **Narrate** **Rani Durgawati's** resistance. ★
- ☐ **Describe** the **Ahom** state: *paiks*, *khels*, *buranjis*, and its land rule. ★ ★
- ☐ **Compare** the Gond and Ahom trajectories.

Start Here: Two Kinds of Society

CASTE-BASED SOCIETY

Divided by rules of VARNA prescribed by BRAHMANAS, accepted by rulers of large kingdoms

Difference between high and low, rich and poor, INCREASED

Under the Delhi Sultans and the Mughals this hierarchy GREW FURTHER

TRIBAL SOCIETY

Did NOT follow social rules and rituals prescribed by Brahmanas

NOT divided into numerous unequal classes

United by KINSHIP BONDS

Land and pastures controlled JOINTLY by the group, divided among households by ITS OWN RULES

Livelihoods: many tribes farmed; others were **hunter-gatherers or herders**; most often they combined **these** to make full use of local resources. Some were **nomadic**.

Where they lived: forests, hills, deserts and places difficult to reach. They sometimes **clashed with the more powerful caste-based societies**, and **in various ways retained their freedom and preserved their separate culture**.

★ But NCERT's key point is **interdependence**: "*the caste-based and tribal societies also **depended on each other** for their diverse needs. This caused **both** societies to change.*" **Not two sealed worlds — two worlds in constant exchange, each transformed by it.** That framing is what a good Mains answer needs.

★ Why tribal history is hard to write

Problem	Consequence
Contemporary historians and travellers give very scanty information about tribes	The written record is thin and external
A few exceptions apart, tribal people did not keep written records	No internal documentary voice
But they preserved rich customs and ORAL TRADITIONS , passed to each new generation	★ Present-day historians have started using such oral traditions to write tribal histories

🎯 **This is Class 6 Chapter 1's "silence of the sources" again, and the methodological response is important.** Using oral tradition as evidence is a genuine methodological shift — it treats memory as a source rather than dismissing it as unreliable. **Quote it whenever you write about marginalised histories.**

📖 The written record has a **systematic sampling bias** — it captures literate, state-adjacent, tax-paying society. Oral tradition is the only channel carrying data from outside that sample.

1 Who Were the Tribal People? — The Regional Map ★ ★

This table is the main Prelims payload of the chapter.

Region	Tribes	Notes
Punjab	Khokhar	Influential during the 13th and 14th centuries
Punjab	Gakkhar	Later more important; their chief Kamal Khan Gakkhar was made a noble (mansabdar) by Akbar ★
Multan and Sind	Langahs, Arghuns	Dominated extensive regions before being subdued by the Mughals
North-west	Balochis	Large and powerful; divided into many smaller clans under different chiefs
Western Himalaya	Gaddis	★ A shepherd tribe
North-east	Nagas, Ahoms and many others	The distant north-east was entirely dominated by tribes
Bihar and Jharkhand	Cheros	Chiefdoms emerged by the 12th century
Bihar, Jharkhand, Orissa, Bengal	Mundas, Santals	
Maharashtra highlands, Karnataka	Kolis, Berads	Kolis also in Gujarat
Further south	Koragas, Vetars, Maravars	
Western and central India	BHILS ★	By the late 16th century many had become settled agriculturists and some even zamindars ; many Bhil clans nevertheless remained hunter-gatherers
Chhattisgarh, MP, Maharashtra, Andhra Pradesh	GONDS ★	In great numbers

★ **The Chero episode: Raja Man Singh**, Akbar's famous general, **attacked and defeated the Cheros in 1591**. A large amount of **booty** was taken, **but they were not entirely subdued**. Under **Aurangzeb**, Mughal forces **captured many Chero fortresses and subjugated the tribe**.

💡 **The Bhils are the best single illustration of the chapter's argument:** within one tribe, **some became settled farmers and even zamindars while others stayed hunter-gatherers**. Tribal society was not static or uniform — it **differentiated internally** under pressure from the expanding agrarian state.

2 ★ ★ Nomads and Mobile People

Nomadic pastoralists

What they did
Moved over long distances with their animals
Lived on milk and other pastoral products
Exchanged wool, ghee, etc. with settled agriculturists for grain, cloth, utensils and other products
Bought and sold goods as they moved, transporting them on their animals

The Banjaras — the most important trader-nomads ★★

Fact	Detail
Their caravan was called	TANDA ★
Alauddin Khalji (Ch.3)	Used the Banjaras to transport grain to the city markets
Jahangir	Wrote in his memoirs that the Banjaras carried grain on their bullocks from different areas and sold it in towns
Military role	They transported food grain for the Mughal army during campaigns. ★ With a large army there could be 100,000 bullocks carrying grain

★ **Peter Mundy**, an **English trader** who came to India in the **early seventeenth century**, described them:

"In the morning we met a TANDA of Banjaras with 14,000 OXEN. They were all laden with grains such as wheat and rice ...

These Banjaras carry their HOUSEHOLD -- wives and children -- along with them. ONE TANDA CONSISTS OF MANY FAMILIES.

They OWN their oxen. They are sometimes hired by merchants, but MOST COMMONLY THEY ARE THEMSELVES MERCHANTS.

They BUY GRAIN WHERE IT IS CHEAPLY AVAILABLE and carry it to places where it is DEARER. From there they again reload their oxen...

They travel not more than 6 or 7 MILES A DAY -- that, too, in the cool weather. After unloading their oxen, they turn them free to graze."

★★ **Why the Banjaras deserve real attention** — NCERT's own discussion question is "*Were the Banjaras important for the economy?*" and the answer is emphatically yes:

- They were **the bulk logistics network of medieval India**. No railways, no roads worth the name — grain moved because the Banjaras moved it
- They were **not merely carriers but merchants** — buying cheap, selling dear, **absorbing the price risk themselves**
- They **fed armies**, which made them **strategically essential** to both the Sultanate and the Mughals
- **100,000 bullocks** for one campaign gives the scale

 They were **a distributed, self-owned logistics-and-arbitrage network** — the operators owned the assets, carried their families with them, and profited from **spatial price differences**. A state that wanted grain in a city did not build a supply chain; it **hired an existing one**.

Other mobile groups

Group	Activity
Pastoral tribes	Reared and sold animals — cattle and horses — to prosperous people
Petty pedlars (different castes)	Travelled village to village making and selling ropes, reeds, straw matting, coarse sacks
Mendicants	Sometimes acted as wandering merchants
Castes of entertainers	Performed in different towns and villages for a livelihood

From *varna* to *jati*

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As the ECONOMY and the NEEDS OF SOCIETY GREW,
people with NEW SKILLS were required
    |
    v
Smaller castes -- JATIS -- emerged WITHIN VARNAS
-> new jatis appeared even amongst the BRAHMANAS
    |
    v
Many TRIBES and social groups were TAKEN INTO
caste-based society and GIVEN THE STATUS OF JATIS
    |
    v
Specialised artisans -- SMITHS, CARPENTERS, MASONS --
were recognised as SEPARATE JATIS by the Brahmanas
    |
    v
*** JATI, rather than VARNA, became the BASIS for
    ORGANISING SOCIETY. ***
  
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★★★ That final line is one of the most important sentences in the whole book. Class 6 Ch.4 gave you *varna* — four neat categories from the *Purusha Sukta*. **This is where the real, lived structure takes over.** *Varna* remained the theory; **jati became the practice**, and it was flexible enough to absorb new occupations and whole tribes.

🎯 **Essential for GS1 Indian Society.** When a question asks about the caste system, the sophisticated answer distinguishes **varna (four, textual, pan-Indian, static)** from **jati (thousands, local, occupational, absorptive, ranked differently in different regions)** — and this chapter is where you get the historical mechanism.

★ **The Uyyakondan Udaiyar inscription** — a **twelfth-century** inscription from **Tiruchirapalli taluka, present-day Tamil Nadu** — records the deliberations of a **sabha of Brahmanas** (Ch.2!) on the status of a group called **rathakaras** (literally **chariot makers**). They **laid down their occupations**:

- **Architecture**
- **Building coaches and chariots**
- **Erecting gateways for temples with images in them**
- **Preparing wooden equipment used to perform sacrifices**
- **Building mandapas**
- **Making jewels for the king**

🎯 **This is caste being manufactured, in writing, by a committee.** A group's occupational boundaries — and therefore its rank — were **deliberated and fixed by an assembly of Brahmanas**. It's rare, concrete documentary evidence of how jati status was actually produced, rather than simply inherited. **Excellent, specific Mains material.**

🐎 Tribes becoming Rajputs — and the catch ★★

New **Rajput clans** became powerful by the **eleventh and twelfth centuries**, from lineages such as the **Hunas, Chandelas, Chalukyas** and others. ★ **Some of these had been tribes earlier.** They came to be regarded as Rajputs and **gradually replaced the older rulers, especially in agricultural areas.**

The rise of Rajput clans set an example for tribal people to follow. With the support of the **Brahmanas**, many tribes became part of the caste system.

⚠️ ★ ★ But read the qualification carefully — it is the sharpest social point in the chapter:

"But only the **LEADING TRIBAL FAMILIES** could join the **RULING CLASS**. A **LARGE MAJORITY** joined the **LOWER JATIS** of caste society."

Assimilation was not equal. The chief became a Rajput; his people became low-caste. **The tribe was absorbed, but its internal hierarchy was created in the process** — an egalitarian kinship society entering caste society split along the way.

🎯 This is a **first-rate GS1 point** on how absorption into a dominant social order reproduces inequality rather than dissolving it.

★ **The exception:** many **dominant tribes of Punjab, Sind and the North-West Frontier had adopted ISLAM quite early.** They **continued to reject the caste system.** *"The unequal social order, prescribed by orthodox Hinduism, was not widely accepted in these areas."*

4 ★ ★ A Closer Look: THE GONDS

Aspect	Detail
Where	A vast forested region called GONDWANA — "country inhabited by Gonds"
Livelihood	Practised SHIFTING CULTIVATION ★
Structure	The large tribe was divided into many smaller clans , each with its own raja or rai
The opening	About the time the power of the Delhi Sultans was declining , a few large Gond kingdoms began to dominate the smaller Gond chiefs
★ The source	The AKBAR NAMA mentions the Gond kingdom of GARHA KATANGA , which had 70,000 VILLAGES

🏠 Gond administration — the three-tier structure ★ ★

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THE KINGDOM
|
+--> divided into GARHS
|    (each GARH controlled by a particular GOND CLAN)
|
+--> each garh further divided into units of 84 VILLAGES
|    called CHAURASI          [chaurasi = 84]
|
+--> each chaurasi subdivided into BARHOTS
|    made up of 12 VILLAGES each [barhot ~ 12]
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🎯 **Memory hook:** **chaurasi = 84** (from *chaurasi*, Hindi for eighty-four) and **barhot = 12**. Garh → chaurasi (84) → barhot (12). The numbers are asked directly.

⚖️ How the state changed Gond society

The emergence of large states CHANGED the nature of Gond society

Their basically EQUAL society gradually got divided into UNEQUAL SOCIAL CLASSES



BRAHMANAS received LAND GRANTS from the Gond rajas and became influential



Gond chiefs now wished to be RECOGNISED AS RAJPUTS

★ The Garha Katanga story:

Person	Detail
Aman Das	The Gond raja of Garha Katanga ; assumed the title SANGRAM SHAH ★
Dalpat	His son; married princess DURGAWATI , daughter of Salbahan , the Chandel Rajput raja of Mahoba
Rani Durgawati ★★	Dalpat died early ; she ruled, and under her the kingdom became even more extensive
1565 ★	Mughal forces under ASAF KHAN attacked Garha Katanga. A strong resistance was put up by Rani Durgawati. She was defeated and PREFERRED TO DIE RATHER THAN SURRENDER. Her son (Bir Narain) also died
The wealth	Garha Katanga was rich — it earned much wealth by trapping and exporting WILD ELEPHANTS to other kingdoms ★
The aftermath	The Mughals captured a huge booty of precious coins and elephants ; annexed part of the kingdom and granted the rest to Chandra Shah, an uncle of Bir Narain
Later	Gond kingdoms survived for some time but became much weaker , and later struggled unsuccessfully against the Bundelas and Marathas

★ **Rani Durgawati is high-value.** A woman ruling a tribal kingdom, expanding it, and dying in battle against the Mughals rather than surrendering — she belongs in any answer on **women in Indian history** alongside Raziyya (Ch.3) and Nur Jahan (Ch.4), and she is a standard name in Prelims.

🎯 **NCERT's question — "why were the Mughals interested in the land of the Gonds?" — has a concrete answer: elephants** (militarily essential), **precious coins**, forest produce, and **70,000 villages** worth of revenue.

5 ★★ A Closer Look: THE AHOMS

Aspect	Detail
Origin	Migrated to the BRAHMAPUTRA VALLEY from present-day MYANMAR in the THIRTEENTH century ★
State-building	Created a new state by suppressing the older political system of the BHUIYANS (landlords) ★
Expansion	In the 16th century annexed the kingdoms of the CHHUTIAS (1523) and of KOCH-HAJO (1581) , and subjugated many other tribes
Military technology ★	Used firearms as early as the 1530s ; by the 1660s they could make high-quality gunpowder and cannons
1662 ★★	The Mughals under MIR JUMLA attacked the Ahom kingdom. Despite their brave defence, the Ahoms were defeated. But direct Mughal control over the region could not last long

★ **Lachit Barphukan** — the Ahom general who **defeated the Mughals in Assam** (at the Battle of Saraighat, 1671), reversing Mir Jumla's gains. He is referenced in the chapter's illustrations and is a live name in current affairs (a national statue and commemorations). **Know him.**

🏰 Ahom administration ★★

Feature	Detail
Basis	The state depended upon FORCED LABOUR
PAIKS ★★	Those forced to work for the state
The mechanism	A CENSUS of the population was taken . Each village had to send a number of paiks BY ROTATION ★
Population engineering ★	People from heavily populated areas were shifted to less populated places. ★ Ahom clans were thus BROKEN UP
Result	By the first half of the seventeenth century the administration became quite centralised
Service	Almost all adult males served in the army during war. At other times they were engaged in building dams, irrigation systems and other public works
Agriculture	The Ahoms introduced new methods of rice cultivation
KHELS ★	Ahom society was divided into clans or khels ; a khel often controlled several villages
Artisans	There were very few castes of artisans , so artisans came from the adjoining kingdoms
★★ Land rights	" The peasant was given land by his VILLAGE COMMUNITY. EVEN THE KING COULD NOT TAKE IT AWAY WITHOUT THE COMMUNITY'S CONSENT. "

★★★ **That last row is the most striking fact in the chapter.** In a period when Mughal jagirdars were stripping peasants (Ch.4), the Ahom state recognised **community ownership of land that constrained the king himself.** It is a genuinely different property regime.

🔗 **This is the historical ancestor of the constitutional protection of tribal land** — the **Fifth and Sixth Schedules**, restrictions on land alienation, **PESA (1996)** and the **Forest Rights Act (2006)** all rest on the principle that tribal land belongs to the community, not to individual transferable title. **Cite the Ahom rule as the precedent in a GS1/GS2 answer and it will stand out.**

💡 Note also what the **census + rotation + forced relocation** system was *for*: **breaking up the clans.** The state deliberately dissolved kinship blocs into an administrative population it could count and conscript. **That is the classic move of a centralising state against kin-based society** — and it worked.

🏠 Religion and culture

Aspect	Detail
Originally	The Ahoms worshipped their own tribal gods
Change	The influence of Brahmanas increased ; temples and Brahmanas were granted land by the king
★ Sib Singh (1714–1744)	Hinduism became the predominant religion
★ But	The Ahom kings did NOT completely give up their traditional beliefs after adopting Hinduism
Culture	Society was very sophisticated — poets and scholars were given land grants, theatre was encouraged, important Sanskrit works were translated into the local language
BURANJIS ★★	Historical chronicles , written first in the Ahom language and then in Assamese

★ **Buranjis** are a favourite Prelims item. They matter because they are **an indigenous historical tradition from outside the Sanskritic and Persianate mainstream** — a third stream of medieval Indian historiography alongside *prashastis* and *tawarikh*.

🌀 **And note the syncretism:** adopting Hinduism **without abandoning traditional beliefs**. That is the normal pattern of religious change in India, and it is a useful corrective to any account that treats conversion as a clean switch.

6 ★ The Conclusion NCERT Draws

Considerable social change took place. **Caste-based society and tribal people constantly interacted with each other. This interaction caused BOTH kinds of societies to adapt and change.**

- There were **many different tribes** taking up **diverse livelihoods**
- Over time, **many merged with caste-based society**
- **Others rejected both the caste system and orthodox Hinduism**
- **Some tribes established extensive states** with well-organised systems of administration, becoming **politically powerful** — which **brought them into conflict with larger and more complex kingdoms and empires**

🌀 **Four different outcomes, not one.** A weak answer says "tribes were absorbed"; a strong one distinguishes **merger, rejection, state-formation, and conflict** — and gives a case for each (Bhils, the Islamised north-western tribes, the Ahoms, the Gonds).

⚖️ Gond vs Ahom — the comparison NCERT asks for

	GONDS	AHOMS
Origin	Indigenous to Gondwana	Migrated from Myanmar , 13th century
Base economy	Shifting cultivation	Settled rice; new methods of cultivation
State built by	Larger Gond kingdoms absorbing smaller chiefs	Suppressing the <i>bhuiyans</i>
Administration	Garh → chaurasi (84) → barhot (12)	Census + <i>paiks</i> by rotation; khels
Labour	—	Forced labour (<i>paiks</i>) central
Sanskritisation	Chiefs sought Rajput status (Sangram Shah)	Brahmana influence grew; Hinduism predominant under Sib Singh — but old beliefs retained
Mughal encounter	Defeated 1565 (Asaf Khan vs Rani Durgawati)	Defeated 1662 (Mir Jumla) — but Mughal control did not last
Historical writing	—	★ Buranjis
Land	—	★ Community-granted; king could not take it without consent

💡 **The one-line discriminator:** Gonds were absorbed and broken; the Ahoms were defeated **but not held**, and they left their own historical chronicles.

Prelims

Topic	The exact thing to know
Tribe–region pairs ★ ★ ★	Gaddis (western Himalaya, shepherds), Khokhar/Gakkhar (Punjab), Langah/Arghun (Multan & Sind), Balochi (NW), Chero (Bihar/Jharkhand), Munda/Santal (Jharkhand, Orissa, Bengal), Koli/Berad (Maharashtra, Karnataka, Gujarat), Bhil (western & central India), Gond (Gondwana), Naga/Ahom (NE)
Kamal Khan Gakkhar	Made a noble by Akbar
Cheros ★	Defeated by Raja Man Singh in 1591 ; subjugated under Aurangzeb
Bhils ★	Many became settled agriculturists, some zamindars ; others remained hunter-gatherers
Banjaras / tanda ★ ★ ★	Trader-nomads; caravan = tanda ; used by Alauddin Khalji ; described by Jahangir and Peter Mundy (14,000 oxen)
Jati over varna ★ ★	Jati, not varna, became the basis for organising society
Rathakaras ★	Chariot makers; status fixed by a sabha of Brahmanas, Uyyakondan Udaiyar , 12th c., Tamil Nadu
Tribes → Rajputs ★ ★	Hunas, Chandelas, Chalukyas; only leading families joined the ruling class , the majority joined lower jatis
Gondwana / shifting cultivation ★	"Country inhabited by Gonds"
Garha Katanga ★ ★	70,000 villages , per the Akbar Nama
Garh / chaurasi / barhot ★ ★	Clan unit / 84 villages / 12 villages
Aman Das → Sangram Shah ★	Gond raja taking a Rajput-style title
Rani Durgawati ★ ★	Daughter of Salbahan (Chandel Rajput of Mahoba); defeated by Asaf Khan, 1565 ; chose death over surrender
Ahoms ★ ★	From Myanmar, 13th c. ; suppressed the bhuiyans ; Chhutiyas 1523, Koch-Hajo 1581
Paiks ★ ★	Forced labour; census ; sent by rotation ; clans deliberately broken up
Khels	Ahom clans, often controlling several villages
Mir Jumla, 1662 ★	Defeated the Ahoms — but Mughal control did not last
Sib Singh (1714–1744) ★	Hinduism became predominant; old beliefs retained
Buranjis ★ ★	Ahom historical chronicles — Ahom language, then Assamese
Ahom land rule ★ ★	Land given by the village community ; the king could not take it without consent

Traps:

- "The Bhils lived in the north-east" → **FALSE**. Western and central India (NCERT asks this as a true/false)
- "There were no tribal communities in the north-west" → **FALSE**. Khokhars, Gakkhars, Langahs, Arghuns, Balochis

- "A *chaurasi* contained several cities" → FALSE. It was a unit of **84 villages**
- "Varna remained the basis of social organisation" → FALSE. *Jati* became the basis
- "All tribal people who joined caste society became Rajputs" → FALSE. Only **leading families**; the majority entered **lower jatis**
- "The Ahoms were indigenous to Assam" → FALSE. They **migrated from Myanmar** in the 13th century
- "Mughal victory in 1662 gave lasting control of Assam" → FALSE. It **could not last long**

Mains

- **Indian Society (GS1)** ★ ★ ★ : "Assimilation into caste society reproduced inequality rather than dissolving it." — leading families vs the majority; the *rathakara* inscription
- **Indian Society** ★ ★ : the **varna** → **jati** transition as the mechanism by which caste absorbed new groups and occupations
- **Polity (GS2)** ★ ★ : the **Ahom community land rule** as historical precedent for Fifth/Sixth Schedule protections, **PESA** and the **Forest Rights Act**
- **Historiography** ★ : using **oral traditions** to write tribal history; the *buranjis* as a non-mainstream historiographical tradition
- **Economy**: the **Banjaras** as the logistics backbone of the medieval economy
- **Women in history**: **Rani Durgawati**

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Tribe	A society united by kinship, not following Brahmanical rules, not divided into unequal classes
Clan	A group of families claiming descent from a common ancestor
Tanda	A Banjara caravan
Jati	Sub-caste; became the basis of social organisation
Rathakara	Chariot maker (a jati whose status was formally deliberated)
Gondwana	"Country inhabited by Gonds"
Shifting cultivation	Clearing and burning a patch, cultivating it briefly, then moving on
Garh	A Gond territorial unit controlled by a clan
Chaurasi	A unit of 84 villages
Barhot	A unit of 12 villages
Bhuiyan	Landlord in the older Assamese political system
Paik	A person forced to work for the Ahom state
Khel	An Ahom clan
Buranji	Ahom historical chronicle
Census	An official count of the population

90-Second Recap

1. **Tribes** were united by **kinship**, did not follow Brahmanical rules, were **not divided into unequal classes**, and held **land and pastures jointly**.
 2. Tribal history is hard to write — **no written records**, scanty external accounts — so historians now use **oral traditions**.
 3. **Regional map**: Gaddis (Himalaya, shepherds), Khokhars/Gakkhars (Punjab), Langahs/Arghuns (Multan-Sind), Balochis (NW), Cheros/Mundas/Santals (Bihar-Jharkhand-Orissa-Bengal), Kolis/Berads (Maharashtra-Karnataka-Gujarat), **Bhils** (western & central), **Gonds** (Gondwana), Nagas and Ahoms (NE).
 4. **Banjaras** were the great **trader-nomads**; caravan = **tanda**; used by **Alauddin Khalji** and the Mughals; **Peter Mundy** saw a tanda of **14,000 oxen**.
 5. **Jati, not varna, became the basis of social organisation** — new jatis formed for new occupations, and whole tribes were admitted as jatis.
 6. The **rathakara** inscription shows a **sabha of Brahmanas formally fixing a group's occupations and status**.
 7. **Tribes became Rajputs** (Hunas, Chandelas, Chalukyas) — **but only leading families joined the ruling class; the majority entered lower jatis**. Tribes of Punjab, Sind and the NWF adopted **Islam** and **rejected caste**.
 8. **Gonds: Gondwana, shifting cultivation**, clans under rajas; **Garha Katanga** had **70,000 villages** (*Akbar Nama*); administered as **garh** → **chaurasi (84)** → **barhot (12)**.
 9. **Aman Das took the title Sangram Shah**; **Rani Durgawati** expanded the kingdom and **died rather than surrender** to **Asaf Khan** in **1565**. The state was rich from **exporting wild elephants**.
 10. **Ahoms** came from **Myanmar** in the **13th century**, suppressed the **bhuiyans**, annexed the **Chhutiyas (1523)** and **Koch-Hajo (1581)**, and had **firearms by the 1530s** and **cannon by the 1660s**.
 11. **Ahom administration** rested on **forced labour (paiks)**, a **census**, **rotation**, and the deliberate **breaking up of clans**; society was organised in **khels**.
 12. ★ **Ahom land was granted by the village community, and the king could not take it away without consent**.
 13. Under **Sib Singh (1714–1744)** Hinduism became predominant, **but traditional beliefs were retained**. The Ahoms wrote **buranjis**.
 14. **Both societies changed through interaction** — some tribes merged, some rejected caste, some built states, and those states came into conflict with empires.
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Test Yourself

Prelims style

1. Consider the following statements:
 1. The Bhils were spread across western and central India.
 2. By the late sixteenth century some Bhils had become zamindars.
 3. All Bhil clans had abandoned hunting and gathering by then. → *1 and 2 only. Many clans **remained** hunter-gatherers.*
2. In Gond administration, a *chaurasi* was — → *A unit of 84 villages; it was subdivided into barhots of 12 villages each.*
3. Consider the following pairs:
 1. Tanda — Banjara caravan

2. Paik — forced labourer in the Ahom state
3. Buranji — Gond historical chronicle → *1 and 2 only. Buranjis were **Ahom** chronicles.*
4. With reference to the Ahom state, which is/are correct?
 1. The Ahoms migrated from present-day Myanmar in the thirteenth century.
 2. A census was taken and paiks were sent by rotation.
 3. The king could take away a peasant's land at will. → *1 and 2 only. **The king could not take land without the village community's consent.***
5. Rani Durgawati was defeated in 1565 by Mughal forces under — → *Asaf Khan.*

Mains style

6. "The assimilation of tribes into caste society reproduced hierarchy rather than removing it." Discuss. **(250 words)**
7. Examine how *jati* replaced *varna* as the organising principle of Indian society during the medieval period. **(250 words)**
8. "The Ahom rule that a king could not alienate community land anticipates modern protections for tribal land." Comment. **(150 words)**
9. Assess the economic importance of nomadic and itinerant groups in medieval India. **(150 words)**

Self-check (out loud, no notes):

- Name five tribes and their regions.
- What was a *tanda*, and why did rulers need the Banjaras?
- Explain in one sentence how *jati* displaced *varna*.
- Give the Gond administrative hierarchy with its numbers.
- What were *paiks*, and what was the census actually for?
- State two ways the Ahom state differed from the Gond state.